

Part I — The Rehearsal

WHY THIS PART — WHAT IS HAPPENING AND WHY

The curtain rises on a bare stage with a circle of chairs and nothing else. Working lights. No furniture, no flats, no props. The Manager arrives at his theatre to a half-rehearsed company seated in those chairs in various postures of professional boredom. The play they are meant to rehearse this morning is one of Pirandello's own — *Mixing It Up* — which the Manager believes is unstageable, and which his contract has forced him to stage anyway. He bickers with the Leading Man about being asked to wear a cook's cap in a serious play. He insults the playwright. He insults the script. He insults the conditions under which any working theatre is forced to operate. None of this surprises his actors, who have heard it before; some are tying their shoes, some are reading the paper, none is rehearsing.

The Prompter takes his place in the box, complaining about the draught. The Property Man enters with furniture for an entirely different scene than the one being rehearsed. The Door-keeper waits at the back of the house with a stack of unread letters. The apparatus of the working theatre — irritation, vanity, exhaustion, the small professional dignities — is performing itself, for nobody it knows is watching.

The audience watches all of this comedy and does not yet know it is watching a comedy. The play has not announced itself. We are inside the engine room of the production, not the production. There is no Pirandello here yet, except in the contract burning quietly on the table.

THE SCRIPT, LINE BY LINE — WITH WHAT EACH LINE IS DOING

The spectators will find the curtain raised and the stage as it usually is during the day time. It will be half dark, and empty, so that from the beginning the public may have the impression of an impromptu performance. Prompter's box and a small table and chair for the manager.

Two other small tables and several chairs scattered about as during rehearsals.

*The **Actors** and **Actresses** of the company enter from the back of the stage: first one, then another, then two together; nine or ten in all. They are about to rehearse a Pirandello play: *Mixing it Up*. [Il giuoco delle parti.] Some of the company move off towards their dressing rooms. The **Prompter** who has the "book" under his arm, is waiting for the manager in order to begin the rehearsal.*

*The **Players**, some standing, some sitting, chat in two languages and check their phones. One scrolls yesterday's 24 heures; another mutters her lines under her breath. Somebody, in the wings, is making coffee.*

*Finally, the **Manager** enters with the precise weariness of a man who has been managing the Village Players for too long. He goes to the table prepared for him. His **Secretary** brings him his mail, through which he glances with the expression of one who has never, in his life, received good news from an envelope. The **Prompter** takes his seat, turns on a light, and opens the "book."*

Exhaustion swinging at the world before the day even starts; the bluster braces him against an institution that brings him nothing but bad news.

THE MANAGER [throwing the morning's letters onto the table]. No. No. Not another one. If it's a bill, a complaint, or a note from somebody with "thoughts about the theatre," burn it before I read it.

Dry and unbothered, already a step ahead of him — one flat fact punctures his theatrics and sets the company's broke, wry tone.

PLAYER 2 [she has been at work an hour; not looking up from her clipboard]. It's all three, sir. The same envelope.

He turns dread into a joke about failure, mocking the room because it mirrors the company he fears they've become.

THE MANAGER *[looking round the half-lit room]*. And who opened this room? It looks like a waiting room for actors nobody called back.

Vanity disguised as wit — he'd rather be cleverly doomed than ignored, grabbing the joke before it can land on him.

PLAYER 1 *[settling himself, to no one in particular]*. Then for once we are perfectly cast.

He swats the ego and begs for light in one breath, running the room on irritation because it's the only fuel left.

THE MANAGER. Don't be charming, sir — it costs extra, and we can't afford it. *[to the Property Man]* A little light, please — if the house has any left to spare us this evening.

The whole production's poverty in four words; stated without complaint, which makes it bite harder.

PLAYER 2 *[a light comes down on to the stage]*. Half light. It's what's left.

He makes the shortage a punchline — then the mask slips for a single breath: 'God help us' is the fear all the bravado is built to hide.

THE MANAGER. Half light, half a company, half a budget. *[a beat]* We're ready for Pirandello. *[quietly, almost to himself]* God help us.

He claps the fear away and snaps back into command — bravado is the only management he has left.

THE MANAGER *[clapping his hands]*. Come along! Second act of "Mixing It Up" — and play it, this once, as if you wanted the public back for the third.

He reaches for the one memory that flatters him, propping his standing on a single ancient success.

PLAYER 1 *[settling himself]*. The public came back for the third act once.

Two words that quietly call his bluff and dare him to overclaim.

PLAYER 2 *[not looking up]*. For you?

He doubles down with absurd precision; the distinction means nothing, which is exactly why it lands.

PLAYER 1. During me. There's a difference.

The intern just does the job, reading the stage description — grounding the chaos in the dull machinery of a real rehearsal.

PLAYER 3 *[reading the "book"]*. "Leo Gala's house. A curious room serving as dining-room and study."

A brisk director's order that assumes resources the company plainly doesn't have.

THE MANAGER *[to the Property Man]*. Fix up the old red room.

She answers fantasy with inventory; the correction exposes how little is actually there to work with.

PLAYER 2 *[noting it down]*. The red room is blue now. We painted over it in March.

He waves reality away — the director's reflex of willing the impossible into being.

THE MANAGER. Then make it red.

A flick of contempt, then she fixes it anyway: the joke names the poverty, the action proves she holds the place together.

PLAYER 2. With what, sir? Hope? *[a beat]* Same flats as the blue room. I'll turn them round.

He reads on, oblivious, delivering the very cue that will detonate Player 1's vanity.

PLAYER 3 *[reading from the "book"]*. "When the curtain rises, Leo Gala, in cook's cap and apron, is busy beating an egg in a cup..."

Granted and retracted in one breath — the running gag of a theatre that can't afford its own props.

THE MANAGER *[before anyone can object]*. Yes — real eggs, if the budget runs to it. *[it does not]* Mime them.

The real objection isn't the cap but the humiliation; he is testing whether his dignity can be spared.

PLAYER 1 *[a small grooming gesture — smoothing the hair before the line]*. Excuse me. Must I absolutely wear a cook's cap?

He hides behind the text to dodge the fight — the script as shield.

THE MANAGER *[annoyed]*. It says so there. *[pointing to the "book"]*

Wounded pride going public; he invokes fifteen years precisely because he fears they count for nothing here.

PLAYER 1. But it's *ridiculous*. I have a reputation in this canton — fifteen years of it, and not one inch built on a cook's cap.

The knife, perfectly dry — she turns his proudest boast into the instrument of his undoing.

PLAYER 2 *[not looking up from her clipboard]*. Fifteen years. And the cap is what finally finishes you.

He stops defending and attacks, recasting humiliation as the actor's sacred task: cruel, funny, and secretly his own creed.

THE MANAGER *[rounding on him]*. Ridiculous? Of course it's ridiculous — that is the whole job. We are paid to make ridiculous things look inevitable. So put on the cap, beat the egg, and become the shell.

He walks straight into it, vanity unable to resist a cue about himself.

PLAYER 1. The shell?

He lands the cruelty as a throwaway directing note — 'try not to overplay it' cuts colder than any insult — then slides into the Pirandello lament, fatigue dressed as erudition.

THE MANAGER. Empty, fragile, and cracked before the public arrives. Try not to overplay it. *[more quietly]* And is it my fault France keeps its good comedies for Paris and sends us only Pirandello — whom nobody understands, and who wrote the thing, I'm told, to leave everyone dissatisfied: actor, audience, and author alike?

An empty threat reached for out of habit, half-hoping to be talked out of it.

PLAYER 1 *[the threat empty; both of them know it]*. I'd sooner resign.

She denies him the drama; routine deflation that keeps the room from tipping into self-pity.

PLAYER 2. He resigns every Tuesday.

Capitulation dressed as defiance — he obeys, but insists on being seen to suffer for it.

PLAYER 1 *[settling the cook's cap on his head with the dignity of a man mounting the scaffold]*. Let the record show I wear it under protest.

He grants the gesture and turns back to work; the last clause quietly confesses how thin the illusion has worn.

THE MANAGER. The record is noted. The record is always noted. *[clapping]* Chair, book — and somebody pretend we are a theatre.

The youngest voice, all fragile hope — a small human request the machine barely registers.

PLAYER 3. Pardon, sir — may I get into my box? There's a draught off that door they've still not mended, and I'd rather not be hoarse for my first proper season.

Distracted permission; the boy's comfort is a matter of admin, not care.

THE MANAGER. Yes, yes — in, in.

An innocent question that is secretly the play's whole subject — and, without knowing it, the door he opens for the Characters.

PLAYER 3 *[pausing at the box, half to himself]*. Do we ever rehearse anything real?

A throwaway joke that turns prophecy: the instant he dismisses the real, the real walks in.

THE MANAGER. Real? God forbid. Real things ruin a rehearsal.

*The white working lights soften into a warm amber — the "tenuous light" Pirandello specifies for the Six. The **Door-keeper** enters from the stage door carrying the **Boy-chair** — the black coat over its back, the cap on its seat, the satchel by its leg — sets it at the edge of the stage, and advances towards the Manager's table, taking off his braided cap. During this manoeuvre, the four live **Characters** — **Father**, **Mother**, **Step-Daughter**, **Son** — enter, and stop by the door at back of stage. The **Step-Daughter** is already carrying the **Child-bundle**.*

A tenuous light surrounds the Six, almost as if irradiated by them — the faint breath of their fantastic reality.

This tenuous light will disappear when they come forward towards the actors. They preserve, however, something of the dream lightness in which they seem almost suspended; but this does not detract from the essential reality of their forms and expressions.

*He who is known as **The Father** is a man of about 50: hair, reddish in colour, thin at the temples; he is not bald, however; thick moustaches, falling over his still fresh mouth, which often opens in an empty and uncertain smile. He is fattish, pale; with an especially wide forehead. He has blue, oval-shaped eyes, very clear and piercing. Wears light trousers and a dark jacket. He is alternatively mellifluous and violent in his manner.*

***The Mother** seems crushed and terrified as if by an intolerable weight of shame and abasement. She is dressed in modest black and wears a thick widow's veil of crêpe. When she lifts this, she reveals a wax-like face. She always keeps her eyes downcast.*

***The Step-Daughter** is dashing, almost impudent, beautiful. She wears mourning too, but with great elegance. She shows contempt for the wretched Boy-chair at the edge of the stage; she shows a lively tenderness for the Child-bundle in her arms.*

***The Son** (22) tall, severe in his attitude of contempt for **The Father**, supercilious and indifferent to **The Mother**. He looks as if he had come on the stage against his will.*